message said ‘Stop firing’; on checking, it turned out the message had not originated from any of the Indian networks. Already the confusion and indecision of the higher HQs was messing with the orders that were being given; these often led to unnecessary troop movement. For example, a platoon under Subedar Haribaksh Singh was moved to Labrang. By last light, the platoon was ordered to return to Battalion HQ leaving behind a section. Just what a lone section of bewildered men in the middle of nowhere were expected to achieve was baffling.

On 16 November, all eyes in Division HQ were on 62 Infantry Brigade as the Chinese prepared to launch their attack on the 4 Garhwal positions at Nuranang. At 6 p.m., 4 Division HQ received the news that Poshing-la, held by a section of 5 Guards and Assam Rifles troops under the command of Captain Amarjeet, had been overrun and the combined force had suffered heavy casualties and had been forced to withdraw to the Se-la–Kye-la ridgeline. Division HQ immediately decided to (a) strengthen the Rajput company under Major K. P. P Nair; (b) move 5 Guards to Thembang and recapture Poshing-la; (c) send three companies of 19 MLI divided into two columns to help 5 Guards; and (d) send one company of 1 Madras from Bomdila and two companies of 13 Dogra from Senge to Dirang Dzong for the protection of 4 Division HQ.

By the evening of 16 November, Anant Pathania had realized just how serious the outflanking threat was and that his sending out units piecemeal had barely impacted the Chinese ingress into Indian positions behind him. His other concerns were now dominated by the fact that his own HQ at Dirang Dzong was completely vulnerable. With no defences at all having been prepared there, the overriding concern now was to delay the Chinese for as long as possible while Division HQ was immediately moved further south.

Subsequently, on the same night, two columns of 19 MLI were hurriedly dispatched from Ewang: Charlie Company under the command of Major S. D. Parab, accompanied by a FOO from the artillery, was sent to Tungri via Sangti and Rungza. The Assam Rifles post at Chhang-la had been withdrawn and there had been no communication with a company of 5 Guards that had been sent towards Chhang-la a day earlier. This column made no contact with the Chinese. Shortly afterwards, Parab was asked to withdraw from Rungza and make his way towards Kachow and take up a defensive position there. At 4.45 p.m., the order was further modified by